

SHORT AND LONG DAYS

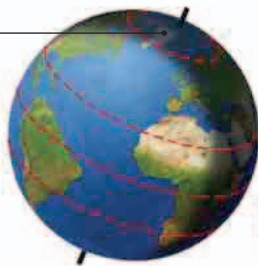
The shortest and longest days of the year, known as solstices, happen when Earth's tilt is either directly facing, or directly facing away from, the Sun. On the shortest day, the winter solstice, the Sun is at its lowest point in the sky, while on the longest day, the summer solstice, it is at its highest. The ancient stone circle of Stonehenge in England (right) may have been designed to mark the winter solstice.



The Arctic is in constant darkness

► DECEMBER

At this point in Earth's orbit, the north is facing away from the Sun, so it receives less sunlight than the south and has fewer hours of daylight.



Arctic Circle

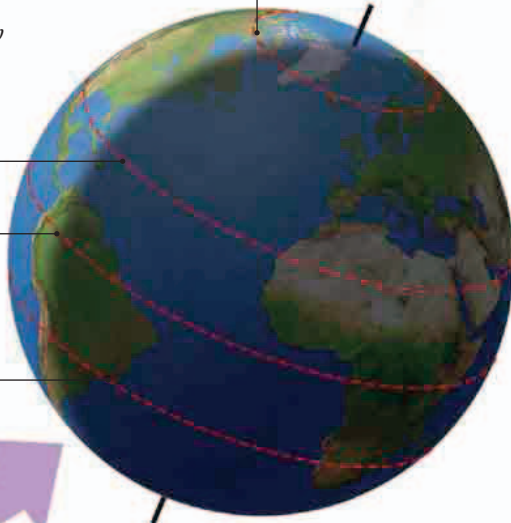
► SEPTEMBER

The north and south are heated equally.

Tropic of Cancer

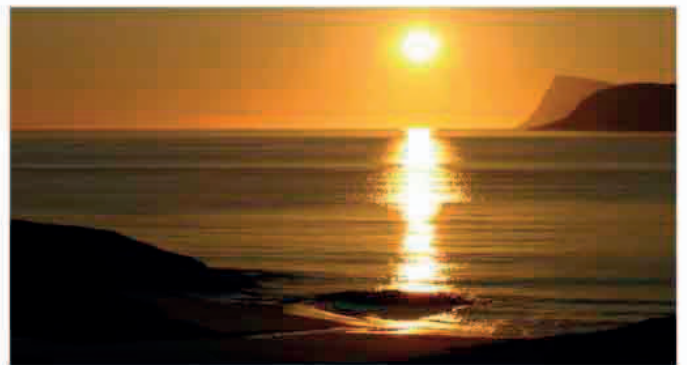
Equator

Tropic of Capricorn



MIDNIGHT SUN

In midwinter, the polar regions get no sunlight at all. It remains dark all day and temperatures plummet to below freezing. But summer brings continuous sunlight, even at midnight, as seen below in Norway. The Arctic and Antarctic circles mark the areas that have 24 hours of darkness on the winter solstice and 24 hours of sunlight on the summer solstice.



DELUGE AND DROUGHT

In the tropics, the zone where the sunlight is most intense moves north and south over the year, as the half of Earth tilted toward the Sun changes. This draws the tropical rain belt—an area of wet weather encircling Earth around the equator—north and south too, causing wet and dry seasons.

► SAVANNA LANDSCAPES

The African savanna is drenched by heavy rain in the wet season (near right) but it is parched to the burning point in the dry season (far right).

